FOREWORD TO FIRST EDITION

The chimpanzee and the human share about 99.5 per cent of their evolutionary history, yet most human thinkers regard the chimp as a malformed, irrelevant oddity while seeing themselves as stepping-stones to the Almighty. To an evolutionist this cannot be so. There exists no objective basis on which to elevate one species above another. Chimp and human, lizard and fungus, we have all evolved over some three billion years by a process known as natural selection. Within each species some individuals leave more surviving offspring than others, so that the inheritable traits (genes) of the reproductively successful become more numerous in the next generation. This is natural selection: the non-random differential reproduction of genes. Natural selection has built us, and it is natural selection we must understand if we are to comprehend our own identities.

Although Darwin's theory of evolution through natural selection is central to the study of social behavior (especially when wedded to Mendel's genetics), it has been very widely neglected. Whole industries have grown up in the social sciences dedicated to the construction of a pre-Darwinian and pre-Mendelian view of the social and psychological world. Even within biology the neglect and misuse of Darwinian theory has been astonishing. Whatever the reasons for this strange development, there is evidence that it is coming to an end. The great work of Darwin and Mendel has been extended by a growing number of workers, most notably by R. A. Fisher, W. D. Hamilton, G. C. Williams, and J. Maynard Smith. Now, for the first time, this important body of social theory based on natural selection is presented in a simple and popular form by Richard Dawkins.

One by one Dawkins takes up the major themes of the new work in social theory: the concepts of altruistic and selfish behavior, the genetical definition of self-interest, the evolution of aggressive behavior, kinship theory (including parent-offspring relations and the evolution of the